

Johann Ravindranathan

GEOG 450

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A Bite to Eat in Ballard

Introduction

Ballard was a familiar name but an unfamiliar face to me. My teammate Chandler and I spent ~ 90 minutes walking through the neighborhood to conduct a field study. After reviewing our observations and sentiments, we developed a radial dendrogram infographic to capture a memorable element of Ballard. This report covers our infographic and its development.

Story

The Ballard neighborhood sits in the upper Seattle region on the north side of Salmon Bay. It has a long history of Scandinavian and maritime culture that predates its inclusion into the city of Seattle [1]. The National Nordic Museum was along our travel route, with local boat launches and maritime art works peppered along the walkways.

We began with a lap around the Carl S. English Jr. Botanical Gardens and Ballard Locks in the southwest corner of Ballard. From there we wanted to travel north to the Ballard Community Center. Due to construction closures, we walked east along NW Market St from 32nd Ave NW to 24th Ave NW, then north to NW 60th St and west until we arrived. Afterwards we retraced our steps back to the bus stop on NW Market St and 28th Ave NW, where we parted ways.

The air was surprisingly quiet and still away from NW Market St, especially in the Botanical Garden and near the Community Center. There was broad use of color for buildings, several art murals, and sculptures scattered around. Sidewalks were wide enough for even large groups of pedestrians to walk in a two-lane fashion.

Our field study was around 1 pm, and yet several restaurants and stores had already closed for the day. We decided to center our visual around these operating hours.

Data

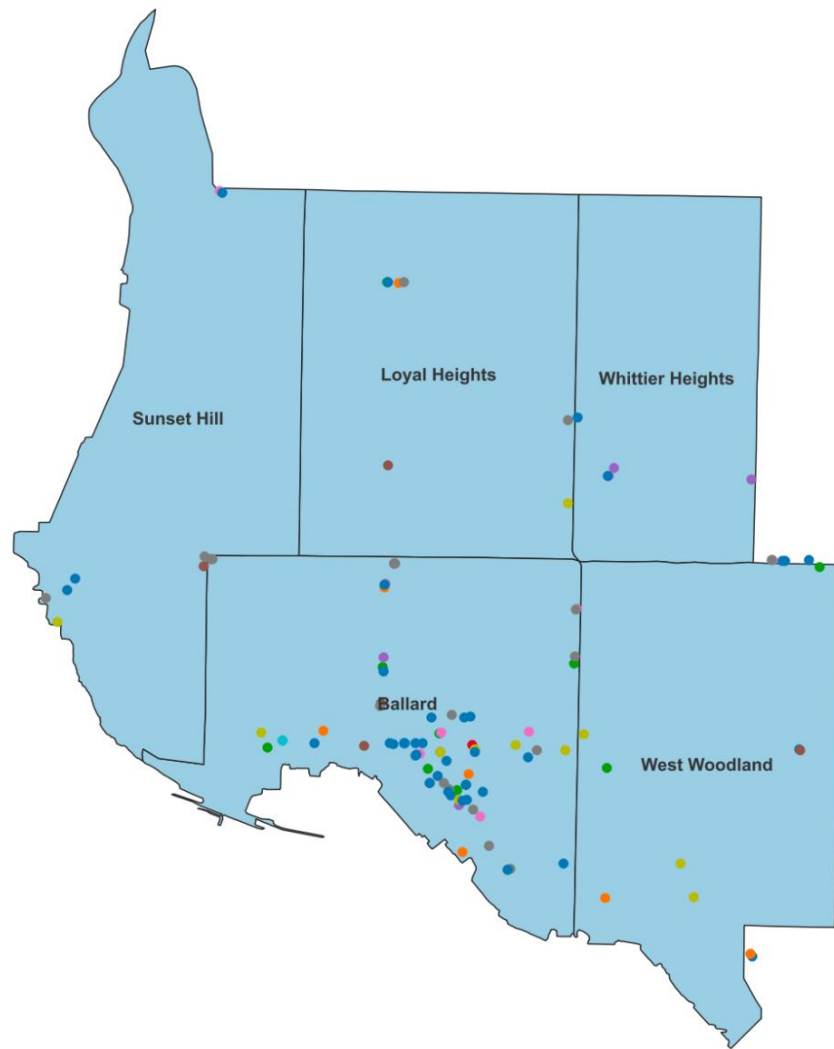
Data was scraped (see Colab Notebook [2]) from Yelp.com using the Yelp for Developers API connection. Our targets were restaurants within the area of Ballard.

Our hope was to group restaurants by their operating hours for our visual. Unfortunately, implementing this required more research and time than we could afford at that moment. We pivoted to grouping simply by the designations of breakfast, lunch, dinner, and café locations. We later also grouped restaurants that could be classified by multiple of these designations.

Charts:

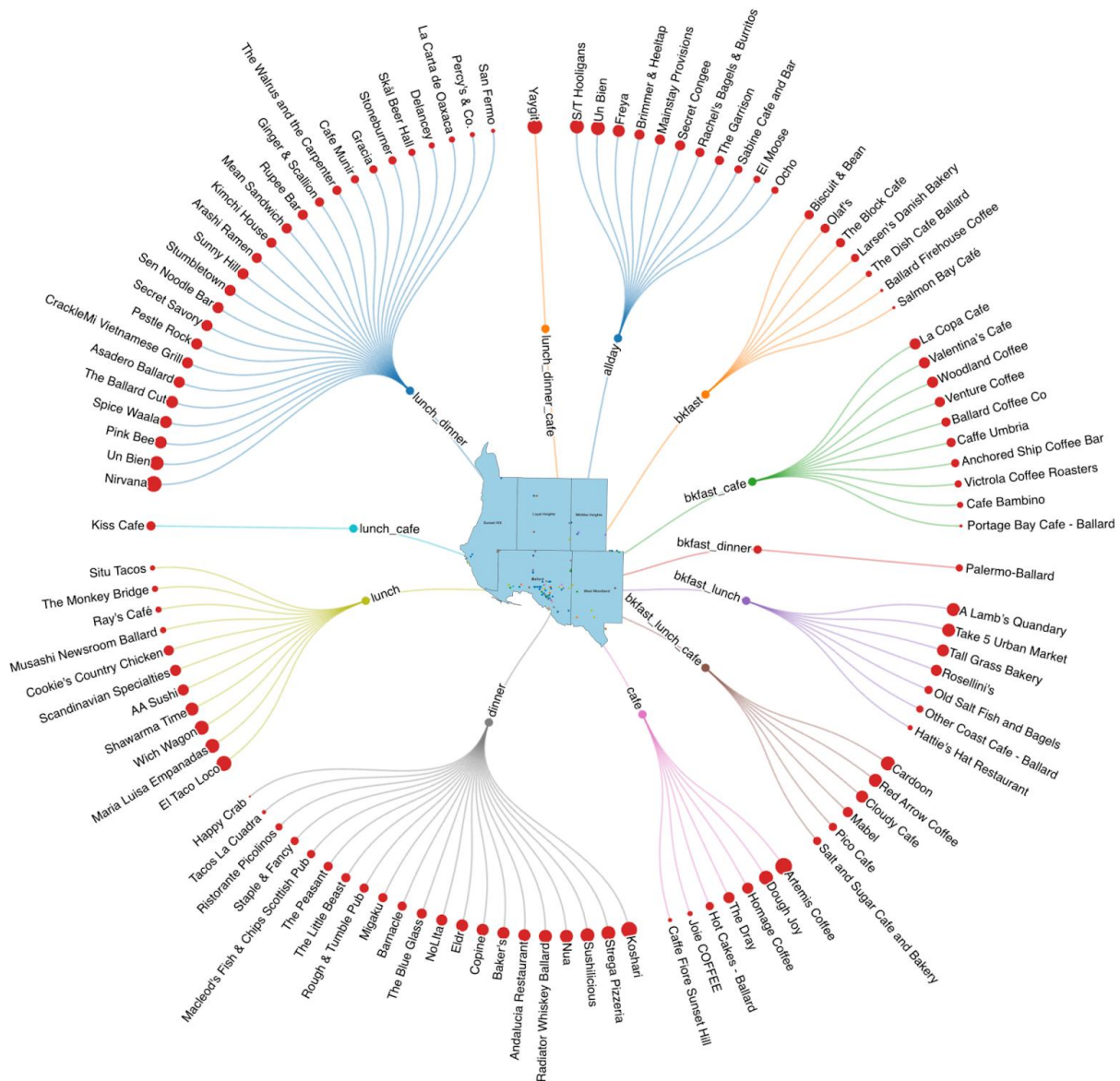
Below are the two graphics we created for visualization:

Fig 1: Map of Ballard with restaurant locations



The above map was made in QGIS using data from the Seattle GeoData portal. It gives a reference for the geographic region of Ballard and surrounding neighborhoods. It includes the location of individual restaurants with points gathered from the data. The point colors correlate with the colors used in our infographic (below).

Fig 2: Our Infographic (Radial dendrogram of restaurants within Ballard, grouped by mealtime served)



Above is the infographic we developed. Starting at the center, it connects Ballard to each of our categories, and from there to each restaurant under its classification. Restaurants were

categorized by the mealtimes they served, which could be several times. The restaurants occupy the outer circle of the visual.

Analysis and Reflection:

Most of the restaurants included in our infographic serve lunch and / or dinner. The spread of serving times suggests it was likely that some of the restaurants we saw shut would have opened later in the day. The largest concentration of restaurants falls along the stretch of road near NW Market St and Shilshole Ave NW, which was at the boundary of our walk.

Part of my hope with this infographic was to capture the feeling we sensed while walking through Ballard. We saw vivid contrasts within our short travel, from the age of construction to busy roads and sleepy streets, and level of development. The experience felt very different from the regions of Seattle I normally encounter. It was apparent from the stores and recreational facilities that the neighborhood enjoys a more artistic streak. I sensed a feeling of relaxation and low tension in Ballard. But this proved difficult to translate into a single visualization, especially with the time and labor limitations we ran into. While our pivot to using self-identified meal specialization was a necessary one, I am curious what our visualization would show if we used our original idea of operating hours. I'm curious if it would lend support to our streetside observations.

References:

1. *Visit Ballard*, Ballard Alliance , www.visitballard.com/. Accessed 8 Feb. 2026.
2. Our Google Colab Notebook:
colab.research.google.com/drive/1qqMUdXOG5s3vxhThs9IBOG4WVEOLrUzq?usp=sharing
3. *Seattle GeoData*, ArcGIS Hub, data-seattlecitygis.opendata.arcgis.com/. Accessed 8 Feb. 2026.

(Our data for the map was gathered from Seattle GeoData by Chandler. I don't have the specifics on which dataset he used. I do know he used a general Seattle dataset and filtered for Ballard, which he then worked in QGIS)